South Asian countries. He spoke of the need to increase interactions so as to boost each other's resources. Interestingly, Rajiv cites Kautilya and justified SAARC on the grounds that the *Arthashastra* spoke of the importance of having friendly neighbours.[104]

When Benazir Bhutto was elected prime minister of Pakistan after the death of military dictator General Zia-ul-Haq in 1988, Rajiv's hopes for peace with Pakistan were raised. Both Rajiv and Benazir were post-Partition leaders and did not carry the baggage of that tragic episode in the subcontinent's history. Both had popular support in their countries and could accomplish what earlier leaders had not been able to do. Rajiv travelled to Pakistan in 1989 to attend the SAARC summit in Islamabad and concluded an agreement with Bhutto on confidence-building measures between India and Pakistan. In the end, however, Benazir Bhutto's term in office was cut short when the president, backed by the military, dismissed her from office and dissolved parliament.

Sri Lanka was the other neighbouring South Asian country with which Rajiv attempted to alter relations. Sri Lanka had a large ethnic Tamil population, which the majority Sinhalese sought to suppress. The Sri Lankan Tamils, who received considerable sympathy from Tamil-speaking Indians, sought protection of their rights. Some demanded a federal system with autonomy for Tamil majority areas within Sri Lanka. All Indian prime ministers, beginning with Nehru, had attempted to solve Sri Lanka's Tamil problem but had not succeeded. In 1983, civil war broke out in northern Sri Lanka as Tamil hardliners pushed for independence after Sinhalese attacks on Tamils.

India's initial role was to ask the Sri Lankan government to protect its Tamil minority. Then, Rajiv went a step further by using the Indian Air Force to drop vital supplies for the Tamil population when the Sri Lankan government blockaded the Jaffna peninsula. As civil war intensified, Rajiv agreed to send Indian troops for peacekeeping after the 1987 Indo–Lanka